

Research Report: Challenges Faced by Home-Based Bakers in Pakistan

1. Introduction

The rise of home-based baking businesses in Pakistan has been driven by social media platforms such as WhatsApp and Instagram. These small-scale entrepreneurs manage custom cake orders, customer communication, and payments independently without formal systems.

This research aims to understand the **daily workflows, challenges, and pain points** faced by home bakers in managing custom orders and customer interactions.

2. Research Objective

To identify:

- How home bakers manage orders and customer data
 - Common operational challenges
 - Pain points in communication, tracking, and payments
 - Opportunities for digital solutions
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3. Methodology

- **Research Type:** Qualitative Research
 - **Method:** Semi-structured interviews via WhatsApp chat
 - **Participants:** Independent home bakers from Pakistan
 - **Sample Size:** 4–6 bakers
 - **Data Collection:** Screenshot-based conversational interviews
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4. Key Findings

4.1 Manual Order Management

Most bakers rely on:

- Phone notes

- Manual diaries
- Memory-based tracking

There is no standardized system to manage:

- Customer details
- Design references
- Delivery dates

👉 This leads to inconsistency and inefficiency.

4.2 Order Errors and Mix-ups

Several bakers reported:

- Writing incorrect names/messages on cakes
- Confusion between multiple orders

These mistakes typically occur during high workload periods.

👉 Errors result in financial loss and customer dissatisfaction.

4.3 Fragmented Communication Channels

Orders and discussions happen across:

- WhatsApp chats
- Instagram DMs

Challenges include:

- Scattered information
- Difficulty retrieving past messages
- Missed details

👉 There is no centralized source of truth.

4.4 Payment Tracking Difficulties

Payments are typically handled through:

- EasyPaisa
- JazzCash

Verification process:

- Customers send screenshots
- Bakers manually cross-check payments

Challenges:

- Time-consuming verification
- Switching between apps
- Risk of missing confirmations

👉 This creates operational stress.

4.5 Customer Query Overload

Bakers frequently deal with repetitive queries:

- Pricing
- Design options
- Availability

This leads to:

- Time consumption
- Mental fatigue
- Reduced productivity

👉 Customer communication is a major daily burden.

4.6 Lack of Centralized System

All workflows are fragmented across:

- Chat apps
- Notes
- Screenshots
- Manual registers

👉 This is the **root cause** of most problems identified.

5. Problem Frequency Analysis

Based on interview responses:

Problem Area	Frequency	Severity
Manual tracking	High	High
Payment verification	High	High
Lack of centralized system	High	Critical
Order mix-ups	Medium	High
Chat management	Medium	Medium
Customer queries overload	Medium	Medium

6. Key Insights

Insight 1:

Home bakers operate in a **highly unstructured workflow environment**.

Insight 2:

Most errors are caused not by lack of skill, but by **poor system support**.

Insight 3:

The biggest stress factor is **context switching** between apps and tools.

Insight 4:

There is a strong dependency on **manual processes**, increasing cognitive load.

7. Problem Statement

Home-based bakers in Pakistan struggle to manage custom orders efficiently due to fragmented communication channels, manual tracking systems, and lack of integrated tools, leading to errors, stress, and operational inefficiencies.

8. Opportunity Areas

A digital solution can:

- Centralize all orders in one dashboard
 - Automatically extract order details from chats
 - Track payments and confirmations
 - Store design references and delivery timelines
 - Reduce repetitive customer queries
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9. Conclusion

The research highlights that home bakers face significant operational challenges due to reliance on manual systems and scattered communication channels. There is a clear opportunity to design a **centralized, automated order management system** tailored to their workflow.

Such a solution would:

- Reduce errors
 - Save time
 - Improve customer experience
 - Lower daily stress
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10. Future Scope

Further research can include:

- Larger sample size

- Quantitative validation
- Prototype usability testing
- Feature prioritization

End of Report